one version in North Gujarat.[41] These, along with commentaries on the *Arthashastra*, were used by R.P. Kangle, Professor of Sanskrit at Elphinstone College, Bombay, to prepare an excellent critical edition of the text, along with an English translation. This edition has been used by generations of scholars to come to grips with the treasure-house of insights and advice that the author of the *Arthashastra* offered to ambitious conquerors of the late centuries BCE.

Notwithstanding the fact that it is widely used for reconstructing Mauryan times, there are sharp differences about the date and authorship of the *Arthashastra*.[42] As with the Megasthenes *Indica*, experts differ over the usefulness of this work as a source in the conventional sense for conclusions about Mauryan material life and culture: unlike the *Indica*, the *Arthashastra* is a theoretical work which does not refer to specific events. The historian Patrick Olivelle has pointed out that there is a 'Kautilya recension' and a later 'Shastric redaction' in which the text's structure was imposed on the original treatise.[43] He also provides various arguments to suggest that the 'Kautilya recension' was put together much after the time of the Mauryas. However, the cultural data on the basis of which he has suggested this is flawed and some of that data actually underlines that the original recension was likely to be of Mauryan vintage.[44] On balance, it is reasonable to consider the core of this formidable manual of statecraft as being anchored in the late centuries BCE. Since it is focussed on the doings of imperial power, an incidental benefit is that it gives glimpses of palace life. Among its various subjects are regulations for the royal residence and its members. In the interstices of its hortatory pronouncements lies some of the context from the time when Ashoka was young.

The palace is described in the *Arthashastra* as standing to the north of the heart of the residential area of a fortified city.[45] The royal residence itself—if the text's prescriptions were to be followed, or conversely if they were based on some idealized form of actual practice—was made up of